

Uberoi, "The Diaspora Comes Home" (1998) — Summary for Your Course

What the paper is actually doing

Uberoi is a sociologist, not a film critic. She uses DDLJ (and its companion film *Pardes*) to argue that popular Hindi cinema in the 1990s became a major arena where Indian society worked out its anxieties about a specific new phenomenon: the middle-class Indian family going global. Her central question is — *can you be Indian outside India?* — and DDLJ's answer is the thing worth examining.

1. Diaspora — the core argument

The "**portable values**" thesis is Uberoi's most important contribution and the phrase you should know cold. DDLJ argues that Indian family values — respect for parental authority, arranged marriage, female chastity, family over individual — are not tied to Indian soil. They travel. The NRI who internalises these values is *more Indian* than someone who physically stays in India but abandons them.

This is a direct response to the dominant anxiety of 1990s India: that emigration = cultural loss. DDLJ says no. Indianness is a portable set of values, not a location.

Uberoi points out that the film makes this argument through Baldev Singh's opening monologue — he has lived in London for 22 years and still feels like a foreigner, still feeds pigeons like he did in Punjab. He is the cautionary figure: the diaspora as *longing* and *displacement*. His entire project as a father is to prevent his children from suffering the same rootlessness — which is why he's so desperate to marry Simran back in Punjab, to physically reattach her to the homeland.

Why this matters for your course: DDLJ was the first Bollywood film where *both* protagonists are NRIs, and the conflict is not India-vs-West but rather different *degrees* of Indianness within the diaspora. Raj (London-raised, failed his exams, fun-loving) has to *prove* he is Indian not by living in India but by behaving according to Indian family values.

2. Masculinity — what Raj's character actually represents

This is where Uberoi gets really useful for you. She identifies a very specific construction of masculinity in DDLJ that she calls the **ideal Indian man**, defined by three traits:

Sexual self-restraint. The hotel scene in Switzerland is the key moment. Raj has the opportunity to sleep with Simran — she's drunk, they're alone, she's not even sure what happened. He doesn't. He then *pretends* he did, lets her panic, and only then reveals he is "Hindustani" and would never compromise her honour. Uberoi reads this as the film's central definition of masculinity: the ideal Indian man *controls his desires*. Aditya Chopra literally said in an interview: "Sex is there, it's on everyone's mind. You just have to know when to exercise self-control and not take advantage of the other person."

Deference to paternal authority over personal desire. Raj is given *two* chances to elope with Simran — once by Simran herself when they reunite in the mustard fields, and once by Simran's own mother who hands him jewellery and says "take her away." He refuses both times. His famous line: "*I want my Simran with her father's consent.*" Uberoi argues this is the film's ideological heart — masculinity means voluntarily subordinating your desire to the father's authority, because this is what proves you are a true Indian. The sacrifice *is* the proof.

Winning through compliance, not defiance. Unlike most Bollywood heroes of the era, Raj doesn't fight the patriarch — he wins him over. He insinuates himself into the family, shares the pigeon-feeding morning ritual with Baldev Singh, and ultimately renounces his claim on Simran in front of Baldev Singh ("*She's yours, you were right, I'm nobody*") — at which point Baldev Singh relents. The hero wins by *performing submission* so convincingly that patriarchal authority willingly gives him what he wants.

Contrast with Kuljeet: Uberoi reads Kuljeet as a foil who represents a *failed* Indian masculinity. He is traditionally Indian on the surface — lives in Punjab, drinks, hunts, has male-bonding — but is coarse, drinks more beer than Raj, hunts for sport, and treats Simran as a trophy. He represents cultural Indianness without the *internalised values* that DDLJ says actually matter. This is key: DDLJ's argument is that the NRI (Raj) can be more authentically Indian than someone who never left.

3. Gender & the film's hidden critique

Uberoi is careful here — she doesn't just say the film is patriarchal, she identifies a subtext where **women's voices consistently criticise the system**, but are then overridden by the narrative.

The most important scene is between Simran and her mother. The mother says explicitly: "*My education was stopped for my brothers'. I sacrificed my life first as a daughter, then as a daughter-in-law. Women are born to make sacrifices for men.*" She then tells Simran to give up Raj and obey the father — not because it's right, but because "*a woman has no right to make such a pledge*" and realistically has no other option.

Later, the same mother reverses herself and tells Simran to elope. Raj refuses on her behalf. So even the moment of female agency — the mother trying to give her daughter a choice — is cancelled by the hero reasserting the patriarchal framework.

Uberoi's conclusion: "**When women speak [in DDLJ], it is to criticise a culture of kinship in which there is no space or time when they can legitimately be the subjects of their own desire.**" Simran's happy ending is "good luck" — she just happened to pick a boy who both her father eventually approved of. She gave in to the system and was rewarded. The film presents this as romantic rather than as what it structurally is: the successful reproduction of patriarchal control.

4. Societal impact — why the film matters beyond entertainment

Uberoi makes two big claims about impact:

For the diaspora community: DDLJ gave NRIs a flattering mirror — it told them their decision to emigrate was not a betrayal of India, and that they could be *better* Indians than those who stayed behind, precisely because they chose their values rather than simply inheriting them by geography. This was enormously meaningful for a community that faced constant suspicion of disloyalty from both sides — too Indian for the West, too Westernised for India.

For Indian society at home: The film projected the NRI's identity crisis back onto India, saying the challenge of remaining Indian in a globalised world is *everyone's* problem, not just the emigrant's. The liberalisation of the Indian economy post-1991 had created new anxieties about westernisation at home. DDLJ's "portable values" argument was a reassurance: you can consume the West (London, Swiss Alps, European holidays) and still remain Indian, as long as you hold the right values.

The conservative ideological agenda: Uberoi is pointed about this. The film endorses three things that are not romantic but structural: (a) the patrilineal joint family as the natural social unit, (b) the father's absolute right to arrange his daughter's marriage — his *honour* is at stake in her virginity — and (c) marriage as an alliance between *families*, not just between two people in love. The "love story" is the sugar coating on a fundamentally conservative reiteration of Indian kinship norms.

5. The one-line version for your exam

Uberoi's argument in a sentence: **DDLJ resolves the anxiety of diaspora by proposing that Indian family values are portable — the ideal Indian man proves his Indianness not through geography but through sexual self-restraint and deference to patriarchal authority, making the NRI *more* authentically Indian than the one who never left.**

Quotes worth memorising

A few key phrases from the paper you can drop in exams (paraphrased, as the paper puts them):

- "Indian family values are portable assets" — the central thesis
- DDLJ frames the ideal man as one who must exercise "sexual self-control" and not "take advantage of the other person" — Chopra's own words, quoted by Uberoi
- Women in the film know the system is unjust, but can only "'adjust' to it and hope for a happy outcome" — Uberoi's summary of the female condition in the film
- Raj wins by demonstrating that being Indian means "respectful of parental authority to the point of self-denial"

How this is different from Uberoi

Uberoi was a sociologist focused on the *family system* and diaspora as a sociological problem. These two sources zoom in specifically on **how masculinity is constructed and performed** in the film — what kind of man Raj is, what Kuljeet represents, and what that means for audiences. Think of it as Uberoi going wide and these going deep on the gender angle.

1. The Central Argument: Competing Masculinities

The IJAAR paper's key move — and the phrase worth knowing — is **competing masculinities**. DDLJ doesn't just show us one vision of manhood; it puts two directly against each other and asks the audience to judge.

Kuljeet depicts absolute masculinity in the traditional sense, but lacks the traits of the "desirable man" — he is not as modern, educated, or flamboyant as Raj. This is a crucial distinction. Kuljeet isn't a villain because he's evil. He's the wrong *kind* of man. He represents the **old masculine script** — physical dominance, regional authority, boastfulness — and the film systematically dismantles that script by making him coarse, leering, and ultimately humiliating. [Academia.edu](https://www.academia.edu)

Raj, meanwhile, is the **new masculine ideal**: the NRI who has absorbed Western modernity (education, emotional articulacy, cosmopolitan ease) without losing Indian values at his core. Raj is the NRI who has not only found prosperity in the diaspora but has maintained the essence of India within him abroad. [Academia.edu](https://www.academia.edu)

2. Raj's Masculinity — "Subversive Within Tradition"

The Substack article coins a phrase that's genuinely useful for your essays: "**revolutionary and subversive without breaking the boundaries of tradition.**" This is the best one-line description of what DDLJ does with masculinity. [De Gruyter Brill](#)

Raj breaks the masculine mould in multiple specific ways the article catalogues:

He is not afraid to occupy traditionally female spaces like the kitchen — he takes part in chores considered a woman's job, such as peeling potatoes and serving guests, helping one of Simran's aunts pick her outfit, and willingly sitting with Simran's Dadi as she sings songs. During *Mehndi Laga Ke Rakhna*, Raj has a dupatta over his head. He also fasts on Karva Chauth for Simran, which is not conventionally done by a man for his wife. [De Gruyter Brill](#)

None of this breaks the structural patriarchal framework — Raj still seeks the father's permission, still positions himself as Simran's "protector." But he signals a **new emotional vocabulary for masculinity**: sensitive, present in domestic space, willing to perform "feminine" gestures of devotion. This is exactly why the film felt revolutionary in 1995 while remaining conservative in its bones.

The hotel scene as the masculinity litmus test: Simran gets extremely drunk one night and he takes care of her across Switzerland. The next morning, she begins to freak out. He pretends they "did it," showing his chest scattered with lipstick marks, and she starts to sob. But then, seeing her distress, he promises her he was only fooling and that he would *never* take advantage of her — that he would never do anything that would ruin her honour. The Substack author reads this as the moment where the film defines Raj's masculinity: it is restraint, protection of honour, care — not domination. [De Gruyter Brill](#)

3. The Dark Underside of the "Romantic Pursuit"

This is where the Substack article gets critical in a way that's really useful for an exam, because it doesn't just celebrate the film — it interrogates the first half honestly.

Raj begins to flirt with Simran immediately. She is very visibly bothered and irritated by him — trying to read but he continues to nag her and get too close. Both verbally and non-verbally, she shows her irritation, and yet Raj does not see this intrusion as anything wrong. [De Gruyter Brill](#)

This pattern continues for about a full hour of the film: Raj embarrasses, teases, or irritates her — and yet doesn't sincerely apologize. She clearly does not want to be with him and does everything she can to get away from him, and yet he keeps coming back again and again. [De Gruyter Brill](#)

This pursuit seems innocuous and is shown as banter — permissible and normal — something that happens between two people who will eventually fall in love. Raj reinforces the idea that to irritate, annoy, and toe the line of blatant creepiness is the way you "get the girl." A woman's rejection is not taken seriously, only her acceptance is. [De Gruyter Brill](#)

This is a direct line you can draw to *Animal*. The article doesn't make this connection explicitly, but the logic is the same: both films frame male persistence past female discomfort as romantic rather than problematic. The difference is that *DDLJ* softens this with charm and eventual respect, while *Animal* strips the charm away entirely.

4. The NRI as "Transitional Man"

The IJAAR paper makes an argument about the **evolution of the NRI masculine figure** in Bollywood that's worth holding onto. While the male NRI can be Indian at heart and live in the West, diasporic women are treated by Bollywood as the allegory of the nation abroad. The male NRI figure is evolving to become a transitionally hybrid figure — someone who can move between worlds — while the female NRI remains the symbol to be preserved, protected, kept pure. [Academia.edu](https://www.academia.edu)

This is an important asymmetry. Raj gets to be cosmopolitan *and* Indian. Simran is only ever Indian — her whole arc is about whether she'll be allowed to choose *which* Indian family she belongs to, not whether she gets to be anything else.

The IJAAR paper also connects this to the post-liberalisation moment: The movie came out only a few years after the 1991 financial liberalisation, with the country opening up to foreign countries and cultures. *DDLJ* shows this transition as something that shouldn't be feared but rather accepted. Raj is the living proof of this argument — you can consume the West, live in it, thrive in it, and emerge more authentically Indian. That's why he resonated so deeply with the upwardly mobile Indian middle class, both at home and in the diaspora. [De Gruyter Brill](https://www.degruyterbrill.com)

5. SRK's Own Discomfort — A Telling Behind-the-Scenes Detail

The Substack article includes a fascinating real-world data point: SRK was not willing to play the character because to him it was a "girly role." As an actor who had played much darker roles earlier in his career, Raj was not "macho enough" for him. And separately, it was Shah Rukh Khan who insisted on there being an action scene at the end — something he said would make the film more "complete." [De Gruyter Brill](https://www.degruyterbrill.com)[De Gruyter Brill](https://www.degruyterbrill.com)

This is gold for a director's POV / cinematography question. The action scene at the train station — Raj physically fighting Kuljeet's gang — was *not* Aditya Chopra's vision. Chopra wanted a purely emotional resolution. SRK pushed for the physical confrontation because he felt the film needed to validate Raj's masculinity in a more "traditional" way before the finale. The film ends up having it both ways: Raj is the sensitive new man *and* the guy who can throw punches when needed. That dual validation is why the character works for such a wide audience.

How This Connects to the Other Two Films

This is the through-line your professor will be looking for:

DDLJ establishes a template: the "good man" is defined by emotional sensitivity + protection of female honour + deference to the patriarchal family structure. Violence is present but restrained and defensive.

Kapoor & Sons interrogates that template — Arjun tries to perform the "good son/man" role and fails repeatedly, because the real emotional truth of the family is something no performance can hold together.

Animal takes the DDLJ template and burns it. Rannvijay's love language is possession and violence. He doesn't court approval — he demands it. The Karva Chauth scene in DDLJ (Raj fasting for Simran — a man doing a woman's devotional act) and the Animal equivalent (Rannvijay literally owning Geetanjali) are almost mirror images of each other across 28 years of Bollywood masculinity.

Who is Anna Vetticad — and why it matters

Before getting into the article, know who wrote it. Vetticad is not an academic — she's an award-winning journalist and film critic who specialises specifically in **the intersection of cinema and feminist politics in India**. She won the Chameli Devi Jain Award for Outstanding Woman Media Person of the Year in 2025, partly for this piece. That positioning matters: where Uberoi analyses DDLJ sociologically from the outside, Vetticad writes as a cultural critic who *lived through* the film's era and is now holding it accountable from within the same popular culture space.

1. The Opening Provocation — the most important sentence in the article

"If there had been no Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge, there may have been no Animal." [Jcoma](#)

This is Vetticad's thesis in one sentence, and it's deliberately confrontational. She's directly addressing the liberals who condemn Animal while continuing to celebrate DDLJ — and telling them they can't have it both ways. The rest of the article is the argument for why.

DDLJ's charms lent a deceptive lustre to its ultra-conservatism, which helped pave the way for the brazen misogyny and Hindu nationalism in Hindi cinema three decades later. [Taylor & Francis Online](#)

The word "deceptive" is doing a lot of work here. Vetticad's argument isn't that DDLJ is as bad as Animal — it's that DDLJ's beauty made its conservatism *invisible*, and that invisibility is what made the ideology spreadable across 30 years of Bollywood.

2. What DDLJ Actually Does to Simran — Reading the Film Against Its Charm

Baldev has promised Simran in marriage to his friend's son in Punjab. Her plea for permission to travel before marrying this stranger — "Can't you, for my happiness, grant me one month out of my own life?" — is the film's most feminist moment, Vetticad argues, and also its most dishonest one. The film raises the question of Simran's agency, acknowledges it movingly, and then systematically hands that agency over to men — first to Raj, then back to Baldev. [Jcoma](#)

The critical point Vetticad makes that goes beyond Uberoi: **Raj does not give Simran her freedom. Baldev does.** And the film frames Baldev's decision to "let go" of his daughter as the emotional climax — a father's love, his greatest sacrifice — rather than as the bare minimum of basic human decency. The audience is made to *applaud* a man relinquishing his ownership of a woman, when the applause-worthy act should have been never claiming that ownership in the first place.

This is "soft-peddling" — the article's central phrase. The patriarchal structure is not just present in DDLJ, it is made to feel *warm*, *emotional*, and *earned*. And that's what makes it more dangerous than Animal's overt version, Vetticad argues.

3. The DDLJ–Animal Lineage — the argument your professor wants

This is the section of the article most directly relevant to your course's parallel-drawing requirement. Vetticad's argument can be broken into three steps:

Step 1: DDLJ normalised the romanticisation of patriarchal control. By making Baldev's authority feel loving rather than oppressive, and by making Raj's deference to that authority feel like heroism rather than complicity, DDLJ taught audiences to read patriarchal control as *love*. The emotional vocabulary of the film — father knows best, honour must be earned, the right man will come for you — was consumed as romance.

Step 2: Each generation of Bollywood escalated what DDLJ established. DDLJ's formula was replicated and gradually intensified through the late 90s and 2000s. The NRI hero became the controlling hero; the father's authority became the boyfriend's authority; the "earned" patriarchy became assumed patriarchy. Films like Kabir Singh (2019, also Vanga) took the next step — the hero *slaps* the heroine and it's framed as passion.

Step 3: Animal is the logical endpoint of this lineage, not an aberration. The condemnation of Animal by many progressives who admire DDLJ reflects the story of contemporary India in a way that requires urgent discussion. Vetticad's point: those progressives are fine with *soft* patriarchy dressed in romance, but recoil when the same patriarchy appears without the costume. Animal doesn't introduce a new ideology — it just removes the charm that made the ideology palatable. [Studocu](#)

4. The Hindu Nationalism Thread — the part most summaries miss

The article's subtitle includes "Hindutva" and this is an angle the other DDLJ sources don't touch. Vetticad argues that DDLJ's conservatism isn't only about gender — it's also about a specific vision of Hindu upper-caste north Indian identity as the default "Indianness."

Recall from Uberoi: the film erases all Sikh characters from a Punjab that was recovering from communal violence. Vetticad takes this further — the film doesn't just erase communal complexity, it actively constructs a **homogenised Hindu-inflected Indian identity** (Karva Chauth, the mustard fields as Hindu pastoral, the Punjabi family as national symbol) and presents this as the universal standard all diaspora Indians should aspire to preserve.

This connects to the broader rise of Hindu nationalist politics through the same period. The film's cultural project — defining authentic Indianness through family values, female modesty, and patriarchal structures — ran alongside, and arguably fed into, the BJP's political project of the same era. Vetticad doesn't say Chopra intended this. She says cultural texts don't need to intend their political effects to produce them.

5. Why the Article's Title Word "Dubious" Matters

"Dubious legacy" is precise. Vetticad is not saying DDLJ is a bad film — she explicitly acknowledges it remains beloved, including by viewers who recognise its conservatism. She's saying the *legacy* is dubious: the film's enormous cultural influence sent Bollywood in a direction that made Animal inevitable. The issue is not DDLJ's existence but the **uncritical reverence** with which it continues to be celebrated.

This is a sophisticated position because it holds two things simultaneously: the film can be aesthetically beautiful *and* ideologically harmful in its long-term effects. That's a more nuanced argument than simply calling it misogynistic.